

Request intake and duplicate handling

OPERATIONS STANDARD

OPS-INTAKE-003

Owner: Dispatch Lead | Effective: 15 July 2026 | Covers email, portal and staff-created requests.

Why the process exists

The intake record is the chain of evidence from a customer's words to Northstar's first action. The coordinator may move back and forth between records while waiting for answers; the workflow below is a decision checklist, not a claim that every request arrives neatly.

Current intake process

- Open the request and preserve the sender, channel, time and attachments.
- Resolve the customer, site and asset from the message and account records. Ask the customer when a material identifier is missing.
- Check for safety language before troubleshooting or dispatch.
- Check the active contract and any later amendments.
- Search recent requests and work orders for the same incident.
- Choose the next action: request information, route for approval, escalate, or prepare a dispatch.
- Record the decision and send the customer a clear acknowledgement.

Duplicate reports

Customers sometimes report one incident through email and the portal. Intake should compare the customer, site, asset, symptoms and timing before opening another case.

An exact retry of a work-order request must return the original work order. It must not create another record. A similar report should be linked to the existing incident or held for operator review when the match is uncertain.

Every accepted request keeps its original request ID and channel for audit.

Minimum information by outcome

Clarification: record what cannot be resolved and ask only for information that changes the next action. Safety escalation: preserve the original wording and duty-owner handoff. Account review: retain the agreement evidence and uncertainty. Dispatch: retain identity, safety, entitlement, resource and idempotency evidence.

Idempotency and retries

Each work-order creation uses an external event ID that remains stable across retries. If the response is lost, query the work-order service using the request or event reference before trying again. A new event ID for the same attempt can create an operational duplicate.

Customer acknowledgements

The acknowledgement should say what Northstar understood, what will happen next and what information is still needed. It must not expose internal prompts, confidence scores or raw system errors. Never imply that a technician is confirmed before the work-order response has been reconciled.

Shared by Northstar Field Services for this engagement.